



The Donor Went Down to Georgia: Out-of-District Donations and Rivalrous Representation

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Abstract

Most of the money spent in U.S. congressional campaigns comes from donors residing outside the race's electoral district. Scholars argue that legislators accepting out-of-district donations become "surrogate representatives" for outside donors. Yet researchers have neglected a critical question: How do *geographic constituents* react when their representatives accept money from outside donors? We argue that geographic constituents feel forced to share their representatives with out-of-district donors at the expense of their own representation. In an experiment during the 2021 U.S. Senate runoff elections in Georgia, we found that Georgians who learned about out-of-district donations to particular candidates expected their senator to spend significantly less time and effort working for the interest of Georgians. A follow-up experiment during the 2022 U.S. Senate elections identified local identity as a moderating variable. Relative to those receiving no prime, respondents whose local identity was primed and who learned about out-of-district donations expected their senator to spend less time and effort working for geographic constituents. Our findings highlight the rivalrous nature of representation and the trade-offs accompanying out-of-district donations and surrogate representation.

Keywords Representation · Public opinion · Money in politics · Campaign finance · Rivalrous representation · Out-of-district donations

Introduction

Six weeks before the 2021 runoff elections to decide both of Georgia's next United States senators, the Senate Leadership Fund, a Mitch McConnell-linked super PAC, aired an advertisement lambasting Democratic candidate Jon Ossoff for taking money from donors outside of Georgia: "liberal mega-donors are backing Ossoff with untold millions in dark money. As Californians descend on Georgia for Ossoff,

he backs their radical agenda.”¹ These out-of-district donations (ODDs)² were a common theme of attack ads against both Ossoff and fellow Democratic candidate Raphael Warnock; one commentator on Fox Business went so far as to label them “the California candidates in Georgia.”³ These attacks implied that Ossoff and Warnock would be more accountable to the desires of their out-of-state donors than to the voters of Georgia. Should they win, these ads suggest, Ossoff and Warnock would represent ‘liberal mega-donors’ and Californians—not Georgians.

In fact, all four of Georgia’s Senate candidates—on both sides of the aisle—took an overwhelming amount of their money from donors outside Georgia.⁴ And the Georgia races are not unique; donations across electoral districts have become the lifeblood of American political campaigns. According to Open Secrets, a nonpartisan research organization devoted to tracking money in politics, the median candidate for the House of Representatives in 2020 received only 23% of their campaign funds from in-district donors, while 38% of the median Senate incumbent candidate’s cash came from in-state donations.⁵ In the aggregate, this amounts to over one billion dollars from donors outside a representative’s geographic constituency. A new literature has emerged studying the motivations and strategies of political donors (Barber, 2016; Baker, 2020; Gimpel et al., 2008; Hill & Huber, 2017), finding that representatives who receive ODDs are less attentive to the concerns of their district and more aligned with national trends (Baker, 2016; Canes-Wrone & Miller, 2022; Kujala, 2020).

Scholars studying ODDs hypothesize that donors who fund candidates outside their own districts are seeking a form of nonelectoral representation called *surrogate representation*. In her seminal 2003 article, Mansbridge defines surrogate representation as “when legislators represent constituents outside their own districts” (515). She illustrates the concept of surrogate representation using the example of former Representative Barney Frank, who saw himself as representing all gay and lesbian Americans, not merely residents of the Massachusetts Fourth District. But citizens can also seek surrogate representation, Mansbridge argues, through campaign donations to candidates outside of their district in a practice she calls “monetary surrogacy.” Out-of-district donors can exert power over their surrogate representatives, who anticipate the reactions of their donors (523). Given that most of the money spent in congressional races comes from outside districts, surrogate representation through monetary surrogacy is a central feature of American representative democracy.

Yet Mansbridge and others have neglected an important group: the *geographic constituents* whose representatives accept money from out-of-district donors. By

¹ [FactCheck.org](https://factcheck.org).

² Although our empirical focus here is on out-of-state donations to Senate candidates, we use the more generally applicable term *out-of-district* donations throughout. In U.S. Senate races, the district is coterminous with the state.

³ [The Internet Archive](https://www.theinternetarchive.org).

⁴ [OpenSecrets.org](https://www.opensecrets.org).

⁵ When discussing campaign donations and ODDs, we are referring to donations to candidates given by individuals—excluding corporate donations, political action committees, and so-called “dark money.”

raising money from outside of their districts, the representatives of these geographic constituents serve as surrogate representatives for citizens residing elsewhere. Geographic constituents must in essence share their representatives with out-of-district donors. Because of the proliferation of ODDs in American elections, nearly all American citizens find their representatives serving as monetary surrogates for outside donors.

This paper experimentally investigates the impact of monetary surrogacy on geographic constituents. How do geographic constituents react when they learn that their potential representatives depend upon ODDs? Implementing a pre-registered survey experiment days before the 2021 Georgia special elections, we randomized whether geographic constituents received true information about the overwhelming share of Senate candidates' campaign donations coming from out of state. We found that respondents who learned about ODDs altered their beliefs about their potential senators. Specifically, constituents given ODD information for a randomized candidate expected their senator to devote 9 percentage points less time and effort working for the interests of Georgians.

Respondents in the control condition expected their senator to spend about 59% of their time and effort working for the interests of Georgians. But when people learned about the ODDs taken by a randomized real candidate, they thought that their senator would spend most of his or her time and effort working for non-Georgians. This effect was stronger amongst respondents reporting high levels of place identity.⁶ This makes sense, as constituents with strong psychological attachments to their geographic location may feel the trade-offs of surrogate representation more acutely and therefore react more negatively upon learning of their representative's dependence on ODDs.

However, because we had not exogenously manipulated place identity, we conducted a follow-up experiment explicitly aimed at causal identification. We conducted a 2x2 experiment in the lead-up to the 2022 U.S. Senate elections, manipulating both the salience of respondents' place identity and their awareness of accurate information regarding the average ODD share allocated to incumbent Senate candidates. Because this follow-up study experimentally manipulated the salience of individuals' local identities, we are able to causally identify local identity as a moderator of the effects of ODD information on representational expectations. This analysis shows that ODD information reduces expected time and effort from Senate candidates when respondents' local identity is primed. These results provide evidence that the association identified in Study 1 is causal—heightened local identity causes constituents to feel the representational trade-offs associated with ODDs more acutely.

Our findings have important implications for the role of surrogate representation and out-of-district donations within normative democratic theory. While

⁶ Building on social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1986), we define place identity as holding a strong psychological attachment to one's region or state. This definition and operationalization falls in line with recent empirical approaches to measuring place-based identity (Borwein & Lucas, 2023; Jacobs & Kal Munis, 2023; Nemerever & Rogers, 2021).

Mansbridge argues that surrogate representation is crucial for democratic legitimacy in single-member district systems, we find evidence that geographic constituents see representation as rivalrous. In other words, a legislator's time and effort are finite; their allocation across constituencies is zero-sum. Any time working exclusively for the interests of donors is time *not* spent serving the local interests of geographic constituents.⁷ Ultimately, these results lay the groundwork for new theoretical and empirical work on the trade-offs inherent to representative democracy.

Theory

Should elected representatives solely represent their geographic constituents? Or should they also represent citizens outside their districts? These questions have animated debates since the very foundation of representative institutions (Pitkin, 1967). Edmund Burke famously argued that “parliament is a *deliberative* assembly of *one* nation, with *one* interest, that of the whole. You chuse a member indeed; but when you have chosen him, he is not a member of Bristol, but he is a member of *parliament*” (Burke, 1777, p. 354). Similarly, the Abbé Emmanuel-Joseph Sieyès, a key figure in the French Revolution, argued that a representative does not merely represent the constituency that elected him, but the nation as a whole: “every deputy is representative of the entire nation...All citizens are his constituents”(Sieyès, 1989, p. 1001). Others have held the polar opposite view; in the words of one delegate to the New Hampshire Constitutional Convention of 1902, “I had just as soon not be represented at all as to be represented by a man not from my town. What good does it do me to be represented by a man whose interests belong to another town, and who does not help our town?” (as quoted in Luce, 1930, p. 507).

In contemporary political science, accounts of non-electoral representation generally anchor themselves in Mansbridge's (2003; 2011) theory of surrogate representation (Rehfeld, 2009; Rubenstein, 2007; Tremblay, 2006; Urbinati & Warren, 2008). Mansbridge argues that surrogate representation, defined as legislators representing constituents outside their own districts, plays a crucial role in establishing democratic legitimacy in single-member district systems (Mansbridge, 2011, pp. 627–628). If a minority group member's preferred candidate loses an election, she may not see her preferences, perspectives, or interests reflected in her local representative. But a standard of democratic legitimacy for the overall electoral system can still be met, Mansbridge argues, so long as citizens can see their interests and preferences reflected through surrogate representatives in the legislative body *as a whole* (Mansbridge, 2003, pp. 524–525). Put

⁷ As Baker (2016) notes, this trade-off is real. More outside contributions decrease members' responsiveness to their geographic constituents. In addition, there is a conceptual difference between working for a set of constituents and providing good ideological representation. This difference is what Schaffner et al. (2020) refer to as coincidental representation. In circumstances where the interests of donors and geographic constituents are aligned, geographic constituents may receive high-quality representation even without the representative working in their interests.

differently, rural liberals in Alabama can find representation in a liberal senator from California even when they have never voted in a California election.

Despite surrogate representation's crucial role in conferring democratic legitimacy in single-member district systems, Mansbridge admits that it risks becoming antidemocratic. The primary danger is that wealthier citizens can seek greater representation through increased monetary support of legislators outside their own districts. Without electoral accountability, one way to exercise power over a surrogate representative is through a relationship of monetary dependence via campaign contributions (523). Donors can threaten to cut off donations to their surrogate representatives and thus exert unequal power. Given the overwhelming dependence of elected legislators upon ODDs (Baker, 2016), the leverage currently enjoyed by donors over their surrogates is considerable.

This account of surrogate representation highlights both its potential (for democratic legitimacy in single-member district systems) and its risks (for perpetuating power inequalities through campaign contributions). Crucially, however, Mansbridge's account of surrogate representation neglects a key group—those *geographic constituents* whose legislators accept ODDs and therefore serve as surrogate representatives for citizens outside of their districts. Do geographic constituents perceive a trade-off when sharing their representatives with out-of-district donors?

Mansbridge gestures toward this possibility through the example of former Representative Barney Frank, who candidly viewed himself as a surrogate representative for gay and lesbian Americans:

Frank, who is himself openly gay, has a sympathetic district constituency: 'My constituents at home understand my position...' He points out that he is able to play this role because it does not take a great deal of time and therefore does not detract much from what he does for his district. (Mansbridge, 2003, p. 523)

However, immediately after raising the possibility that geographic constituents may perceive a trade-off to surrogate representation, Mansbridge dismisses it by uncritically accepting Rep. Frank's assertion that his Massachusetts constituents tolerate what he claims is a minimal demand on his time. But if Rep. Frank is wrong—if his constituents *do* view surrogate representation as a significant drain on his time and attention—then geographic constituents may see representation as a rivalrous good, feeling forced to share their representative with outsiders.

Mansbridge does not theorize the normative implications of geographic constituents holding such views, nor has there been empirical work on geographic constituents' attitudes towards surrogate representation. Our study fills these gaps. If geographic constituents view representation as a rivalrous good, both the practice of cross-district campaign contributions and the normative roles of surrogate representation and campaign finance in democratic theory must be reassessed. This leads to the first of our empirical hypotheses:

(H1): Geographic constituents who learn that their candidates receive campaign funds from out-of-state donors will expect their representatives to spend less time and effort working for in-state interests.

In addition to their effects upon the perceived quality of representation, ODDs may also shape how respondents view their role in politics. Past research demonstrates that internal and external political efficacy are shaped by institutional policies and practices (Brunell, 2010; Beaumont, 2011; Jacobs et al., 2022; Lassen & Serritzlew, 2011; Lerman & Weaver, 2014; Morrell, 2005). For example, Morrell (2005) shows that deliberative democratic conversations increase the perceived political efficacy of citizens. In our context, learning about out-of-district donations may make geographic constituents feel diminished influence over their own elected representatives. This prompts our second hypothesis:

(H2): Geographic constituents who learn that their representatives receive campaign funds from out-of-state donors will report reduced external political efficacy.

Relatedly, existing work finds that policies can shape attitudes toward political institutions as a whole (Bram, 2023; Citrin & Stoker, 2018; Craig et al., 1990; Hetherington & Husser, 2012; Levi & Stoker, 2000; Mutz & Reeves, 2005; Parker & Parker, 1993). Most relevant for our study is research on the effects of campaign donations on political trust in congressional institutions. Brady and Theriault (2001), for example, find that the more an individual sees Congress as beholden to special interests and big money, the less trusting they are of Congress overall. On the basis of these studies, we expect that:

(H3): Geographic constituents who learn that their representatives receive campaign funds from out-of-state donors will report lower trust in Congress.

These hypotheses and our first survey were pre-registered with the Open Science Foundation in advance of the 2021 Georgia special elections.⁸

We also explore which constituents feel the trade-off of surrogate representation most acutely. One reason that Mansbridge brushes aside the possibility that geographic constituents could view surrogate representation negatively is that she assumes local issues constitute only a minor part of voters' most significant interests. Mansbridge writes that "the situation has changed from the time when territorial representation captured many of a voter's most significant interests," asserting that these interests can be satisfied *non-electorally* through surrogate representatives (Mansbridge, 2003, pp. 522–523). However, we argue that many voters—by virtue of their strong sense of local identity—*perceive* local interests to be paramount. These voters, like the New Hampshire delegate quoted earlier, may believe that their most significant interests are local and therefore could not possibly be represented by a surrogate from another district nor by the legislature as a whole. This, in turn, may cause these geographic constituents to feel more reliant upon the electoral relationship with the representative from their district.

⁸ See Online Appendix A.2 and <https://osf.io/3tr9y>.

(H4): Highly place-identified geographic constituents who learn that their representatives receive campaign funds from out-of-state donors will expect their representatives to spend significantly less time and effort working for their constituents relative to respondents with low place identity.

H4 is exploratory in Study 1, meaning it is not pre-registered. In Study 2, we conduct a 2×2 experiment to directly test *H4*.

Study 1

Research Design

To test the effects of ODDs on expectations of representatives' time and effort, external political efficacy, and congressional trust, we leverage a unique political context: the twin runoff elections for U.S. Senate held in Georgia on January 5, 2021. These elections pitted Democrats Raphael Warnock and Jon Ossoff against Republican incumbents Kelly Loeffler and David Perdue. In the wake of the 2020 elections, control of the Senate was at stake; Republicans held 50 seats, but Democrats held 48 plus the tie-breaking vote of Vice President-elect Kamala Harris.

The Georgia runoffs were a particularly apt setting to test the effects of ODDs upon geographic constituents for several reasons. First, the heightened electoral stakes grabbed national attention and prompted a flood of campaign donations from across the country. These races were the most expensive of the 2020 cycle, with each attracting around a quarter of a billion dollars.⁹ Approximately 94% of online donations came from out of state, making concerns about ODDs and their effects on legislator-constituent relationships especially relevant.¹⁰ Second, the fact that partisan control of the Senate hung in the balance meant that survey respondents were strongly incentivized to disregard concerns about geographic representation for the sake of partisan gains. And third, our online survey was fielded in the two weeks immediately prior to election day, by which time opinions regarding the candidates were likely to be highly crystallized. Past work finds that experiments on the eve of elections rarely change attitudes or behaviors (Kalla & Broockman, 2018), and in this respect our design constitutes a conservative test of the effects of ODDs on geographic constituents.

Between December 23, 2020 and January 4, 2021, we fielded an online survey of 2006 voting-age Georgia residents using the survey platform Lucid. We ensured that respondents were voting-age Georgians in two ways. First, Lucid screened potential respondents to exclude minors and those not listing Georgia as their place of residence. Second, we asked respondents for their state of residence, excluding from all analyses those who reported living elsewhere at the time. Past research highlights potential data quality issues in Lucid-administered survey samples due to

⁹ [OpenSecrets.org](https://www.opensecrets.org).

¹⁰ [Bloomberg News, December 17, 2020](#).

Table 1 Our initial experiment utilized a 2×2 plus pure control design to test the effects of ODD information

	All candidates treatment ($n = 677$)	Specific candidate treatment ($n = 645$)
ODD prime ($n = 649$)	“Out of all the money that Georgia Senate candidates raised from individuals, what percentage do you think comes from people outside the state of Georgia?” ($n = 347$)	“Out of all the money that [randomly assigned candidate] raised from individuals, what percentage do you think comes from people outside the state of Georgia?” ($n = 302$)
ODD treatment ($n = 673$)	“94% of all money in the 2021 Georgia Senate special elections came from out-of-state donors.” ($n = 330$)	“[Pipe in percentage]% of all money in the 2021 Georgia Senate special elections raised by [randomly assigned candidate] came from out-of-state donors.” ($n = 343$)
Control ($n = 684$)	[No information provided]	

respondents’ inattentiveness (Aronow et al., 2020). We therefore administered two pre-treatment attention checks¹¹ and excluded failing respondents.

To test whether ODDs cause geographic constituents to feel less represented, we used an embedded survey experiment. Because we could not randomize candidates’ ODDs, we opted instead to randomize respondents’ exposure to true information about ODDs in the Georgia runoffs. The experiment used a $2 \times 2 + 1$ design, generating five conditions (Table 1). In the first condition, a pure control, respondents received neither the informational treatment nor a prime concerning ODDs. In the second and third conditions, respondents were asked to estimate what percentage of campaign funds came from ODDs. This “ODD Prime” prompted respondents to think about ODDs without informing them about the massive scale of ODDs in the upcoming runoffs. In the fourth and fifth conditions, respondents received true information about the share of ODDs in Georgia Senate races—the “ODD Treatment.”

What distinguished each pair of conditions was random assignment to an “All Candidates Treatment” or a “Specific Candidate Treatment.” In conditions two and four, respondents were asked or informed about the average ODD share across all four Senate candidates; respondents in conditions three and five were asked or informed about ODDs received by one (randomized) candidate. In other words, respondents in the Specific Candidate Treatment were asked or informed about ODDs to one of the following: Sen. Loeffler, Warnock, Sen. Perdue, or Ossoff. The rationale behind this treatment arm was twofold. First, there were no substantive differences between candidates on the ODD dimension, with each sourcing between 92% and 96% of their campaign funds from ODDs. Second, presenting information about specific candidates heightened the realism of the experiment, since candidate-specific information is more typically reported than aggregate statistics, as this article’s opening anecdote suggests.

¹¹ The first attention check asks how often they have flown in a helicopter; the second asks respondents to identify a stop sign among a set of images.

Table 2 Study 1 sample demographics closely match census estimates

Demographic	Sample statistics	Census estimates (Georgia residents)
Sex	55% Female	51% Female
Race	58% White, 28% Black, 7% Latino, 3% Asian	51% White, 33% Black, 10% Latino, 4% Asian
Partisanship	46% Democrat, 39% Republican, 15% Independent	41% Democrat, 41% Republican, 18% Independent (Pew Research)
Education	22% Bachelor's degree	32% Bachelor's degree
Median income	\$40,000–\$49,999	\$61,000

The demographics of our sample of 2006 voting-age Georgian respondents (see Table 2) closely matched census estimates: 55% female, 46% Democrat, 58% White, 28% Black, and a median household income between \$40,000 and \$49,999. Nonetheless, we recognize that online opt-in samples are unlikely to be representative of a state at large. For that reason we focus not on point estimates but on treatment effects within our experimental sample.

We analyze three pre-registered outcomes. We measure time and effort through two versions of a survey question which vary according to treatment assignment. Respondents in the All Candidates Treatment were asked “No matter who wins, what percentage of the next Georgia senators’ time and effort do you think WILL be spent working for the interests of Georgians?” Respondents in the Specific Candidate Treatment were asked to estimate the expected time and effort of a randomly assigned candidate. We rescale these percentages from [0, 100] to [0, 1], yielding a sample mean of 0.54. Outcome two, external political efficacy, is an additive index of two standard ANES Likert scales, rescaled from [− 6, 6] to [0, 1] (sample mean: 0.35), with higher values indicating greater efficacy. Finally, trust in Congress is an additive index of three questions rescaled from [0, 12] to [0, 1] (sample mean: 0.33), where higher values mean greater trust.¹²

Our exploratory analysis considers the moderating effect of place identity. We operationalize place identity as an additive index of four questions about southern identity (Williams, 2021) rescaled from [0, 15] to [0, 1] (sample mean: 0.57). These items are modified from the social identity scale proposed by Huddy and Bankert (2017), based on Mael and Tetrick (1992) and Greene (1999):

1. “How important is being southern to your identity?”
2. “When talking about southerners, how often do you use the word ‘we’ instead of ‘they’?”
3. “To what extent do you feel southerners in this country have a lot to be proud of?”
4. “How much would you say southerners in this country have in common with one another?”

¹² For specific question wording for efficacy and trust in Congress, see Online Appendix B.1.6.

Table 3 Information and questions about specific candidates trigger rivalrous representation and reduce trust in Congress

	Time and effort	External efficacy	Trust in Congress
All candidates ODD prime	– 0.027 (0.019)	– 0.004 (0.016)	– 0.010 (0.017)
All candidates ODD treatment	0.011 (0.019)	– 0.001 (0.016)	– 0.011 (0.017)
Specific candidate ODD prime	– 0.065*** (0.020)	– 0.019 (0.017)	0.042** (0.018)
Specific candidate ODD treatment	– 0.094*** (0.019)	– 0.009 (0.016)	– 0.037** (0.017)
Intercept	0.588*** (0.011)	0.353*** (0.009)	0.346*** (0.010)
Observations	1, 929	2, 001	1, 994
R^2	0.019	0.001	0.004
Adjusted R^2	0.017	– 0.001	0.002

* $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$

Results

In what follows, we first present tests of our pre-registered hypotheses, analyzing the effects of the All Candidates Treatment, Specific Candidate Treatment, ODD Prime, and ODD Treatment on respondents' estimates of their senators' time and effort, external political efficacy, and trust in Congress. We then present an exploratory analysis of local identity as a moderator of the effects of the Specific Candidate ODD Treatment upon time and effort. These results motivated Study 2.

Hypotheses *H1*, *H2*, and *H3* are tested in Table 3, with coefficients denoting treatment effects relative to the control condition. The All Candidates Treatment is not statistically distinguishable from zero across all pre-registered dependent variables—senatorial time and effort, external efficacy, and trust in Congress. However, as our opening anecdote suggests, real-world information about ODDs typically takes the form of candidate-specific figures, rather than averages across candidates. We evaluate responses to the Specific Candidate Treatment below.

Overall, priming respondents to think about or informing them about a specific candidate had substantively large and statistically significant effects on their expectations of their senator's time and effort and their trust in Congress. Respondents receiving the Specific Candidate ODD Prime felt their senator would spend 6.5 percentage points less time and effort working for the interests of Georgians and trusted Congress 4.2 percentage points less—11% and 12% reductions from baseline rates. Respondents informed about a specific candidate's ODD share reduced their estimates of their senator's time and effort by 9.4 percentage points and their trust in Congress by 3.7 percentage points—16% and 11% drops from baseline.

The upshot of these results is that consideration of a specific candidate's reliance upon ODDs triggers respondents to view representation as a rivalrous good.

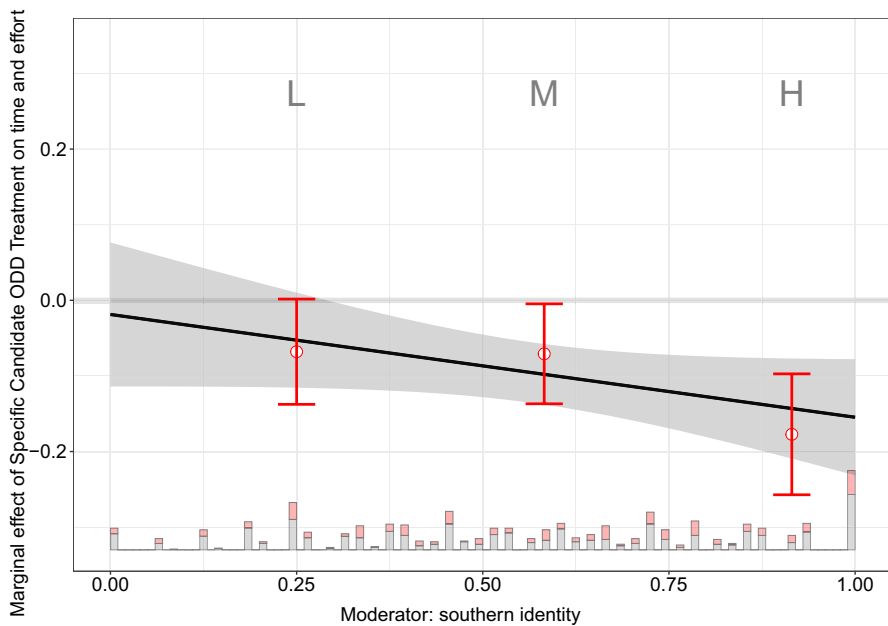


Fig. 1 For respondents high in southern identity, the specific candidate ODD treatment triggers strong feelings of rivalrous representation

Time and effort spent on out-of-state donors is time not spent on local issues. But these respondents do not only expect lower quality representation, they also grow less trusting of Congress. In contrast to these effects on time and effort and trust in Congress, however, no treatment or prime had any effect on respondents' feelings of external political efficacy.

In addition to our pre-registered hypotheses, we also conducted an exploratory analysis of the moderating effect of local place identity on our treatment effects. As noted above, there are good reasons to expect that Georgians with strong place identity will prioritize local interests, and therefore feel the trade-offs inherent to ODD-based surrogate representation more acutely. Following Hainmueller et al. (2019), Figure 1 presents the marginal effect of the Specific Candidate Treatment on expectations of senatorial time and effort conditional on respondents' reported levels of southern identity.

High reported southern identity is associated with a statistically significant decline in expectations that elected senators will devote time and effort to local interests. In fact, the treatment effect upon maximally southern-identified respondents was approximately 14 percentage points greater ($p = 0.079$) than those with the minimum level of southern identity. But because we did not pre-register this hypothesis or experimentally manipulate place identity, these results are associational rather than causal. In Study 2 we manipulate the salience of place identity.

Based on the results of Study 1, we focus on respondent expectations of senatorial time and effort as our primary dependent variable. The logic behind this emphasis is

Table 4 Study 2 sample demographics closely match census estimates

Demographic	Sample statistics	Census estimates (34 states)
Sex	52% Female	50% Female
Race	65% White, 12% Black, 14% Latino, 5% Asian	58% White, 12% Black, 18% Latino, 6% Asian
Partisanship	46% Democrat, 36% Republican	44% Democrat, 37% Republican
Education	23% Bachelor's degree	21% Bachelor's degree
Median income	\$35,000–\$39,999	\$50,000–\$75,000

that time and effort—unique among our outcomes—constitute finite resources. This outcome therefore better embodies the concept of rivalrous representation, as time and effort spent on behalf of outside donors is time and effort that cannot be spent on behalf of geographic constituents. In Study 2, this is the only dependent variable analyzed.

Study 2

Research Design

Building directly upon the insights of Study 1, we designed a follow-up study for the 2022 midterm elections. Study 2 is designed to test whether the effects of ODD information are moderated by feelings of local place identity. We again used an embedded survey experiment on the Lucid platform, surveying 1505 voting-age Americans in the 34 states with Senate races from November 1–6, 2022.¹³ As Table 4 demonstrates, our opt-in sample used demographic quotas to ensure a close match to census estimates of voting-age Americans: 52% female, 46% Democrat, 65% White, 12% Black, and a median household income between \$35,000 and \$39,999. As in the previous study, we focus on treatment effects rather than point estimates.

Our follow-up study utilized a 2×2 design (see Table 5) which independently randomized assignment to (1) an ODD informational treatment and (2) a two-part manipulation of local identity salience. The first treatment arm informed respondents that approximately two-thirds of Senate incumbents' individual donor campaign funds in the 2022 cycle came from out-of-state donors; those in the control group learned nothing about ODDs. The second treatment arm asked respondents to complete two tasks designed to raise the salience of local place attachments. Task one was to unscramble four sentences concerning their state of residence.¹⁴ For example, "A lot Alabama to means me," unscrambles to "Alabama means a lot to

¹³ 1,761 respondents entered the survey, but 256 respondents failed to complete the survey.

¹⁴ See Online Appendix C.1.1 for additional details about this exercise.

Table 5 Our follow-up experiment utilized a 2 × 2 design to test the moderating effect of local place identity on ODD informational treatments

	Control group (<i>n</i> = 844)	Local identity prime (<i>n</i> = 661)
Control group (<i>n</i> = 756)	Respondents receive no ODD information and no local identity prime. (<i>n</i> = 406)	Respondents complete sentence unscrambling task and answer open-ended questions. (<i>n</i> = 350)
ODD treatment (<i>n</i> = 749)	Respondents told that 66% of all 2022 Senate incumbents' campaign funds came from out-of-state. (<i>n</i> = 439)	Respondents complete sentence unscrambling task and answer open-ended questions AND told that 66% of all 2022 Senate incumbents' campaign funds came from out-of-state. (<i>n</i> = 310)

Table 6 Local identity amplifies the rivalrous representation effects of ODD information

	Time and effort
Local identity prime	0.028 (0.018)
ODD treatment	0.016 (0.017)
Local ID prime × ODD treatment	– 0.062** (0.026)
Intercept	0.531*** (0.012)
Observations	1, 505
R^2	0.004
Adjusted R^2	0.002

* $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$

me.” Existing work finds that this approach primes respondents to consider local attachments as opposed to more global ones (Zhang & Khare, 2009). The second task asked respondents to answer two open-ended questions on what they (1) love about living in their state and (2) feel their state should be proud of.

Our key dependent variable focuses on the rivalrous nature of representation. Similar to Study 1, we asked respondents “No matter who wins the 2022 Senate race in [pipe in respondent state], what percentage of your senators’ time and effort WILL be spent working for the interest of [pipe in respondent state]?” This measure is identical to the dependent variable used in Study 1. However, some differences do exist between the two designs. Most notably, Study 2 used a nationwide rather than a single-state sample and consequently presented respondents with a national ODD average for Senate incumbents rather than candidate-specific information.¹⁵ This national average corresponds more closely to Study 1’s All Candidates ODD Treatment, which yielded weaker effects than the Specific Candidate ODD Treatment.¹⁶ A final difference lies in our Local Identity Prime. As a result, Study 2 explicitly tests local identity as a moderator of ODD treatment effects on expectations of representation. To do so, we examine an interactive specification using OLS regression. We expect that the effects of the ODD Treatment will be stronger for those receiving the Local Identity Prime than for those not receiving a prime ($H4$).

¹⁵ The sample included only respondents from the 34 states holding U.S. Senate elections in 2022. These states comprised the nationwide ODD average.

¹⁶ Data limitations precluded construction of a Specific Candidate ODD Treatment in Study 2. Specifically, Open Secrets only posted real-time campaign finance data for Senate incumbents, not challengers or open-seat candidates.

Results

Table 6 presents the results, confirming the exploratory findings of Study 1. The key result is a negative and statistically significant ($p < 0.02$) coefficient on the Local Identity Prime $\times$ ODD Treatment interaction term. The magnitude of this effect is also substantively meaningful; the effect of ODD information on identity-primed respondents was over six percentage points larger than that among unprimed respondents.

We also estimate null effects for the Local Identity Prime among non-ODD treated and for the ODD Treatment among respondents not receiving the Local Identity Prime. These are consistent with the results of Study 1 given the weaker ODD Treatment used in the follow-up study: it parallels Study 1's All Candidates Treatment and provides a substantially lower ODD share (66%) than the initial study's figure (>95%).

Discussion

Our studies demonstrate that many citizens feel less well represented upon learning that their elected representatives receive most of their campaign donations from donors outside their state. But our results come with several limitations that motivate further work. First, the evidence we present comes solely from survey experiments, potentially limiting the external validity of our findings. In the real world, voters are likely to encounter information about ODDs in highly partisan contexts amidst a great deal of competing information about candidates. Using survey experimental evidence allows us to isolate the influence of ODDs on constituent views of representation.

Another potential concern is that our results may be driven by partisanship. In turn, we test for heterogeneous effects based on whether respondents are co-partisans with the candidates in Study 1 (Online Appendix Table B.1). We find that there is no significant effect of receiving ODD information on co-partisan respondents. In contrast, when respondents receive ODD information about an out-partisan candidate, they expect that candidate to work 11 percentage points less for them. This implies that feelings toward one's own side relative to one's opponents are especially important for explaining reactions to ODDs. However, because we find significant results with Study 2, where no partisan information is provided, this suggests that the effects of ODDs on representational expectations are not solely driven by partisanship. Further work should unpack how co-partisans and out-partisans react differently to candidate ODDs.

An additional limitation is that the contexts and research designs of Study 1 and Study 2 differ. While Study 1 includes the Specific Candidates condition, where respondents see a particular Senate candidate and their ODD shares, Study 2 only includes an All Candidates condition, where respondents see the ODD amounts for all (incumbent) Senators. This difference occurred because ODD amounts for challenger candidates in the 2022 midterms were not available at the time our survey launched. In Study 1, the Georgia runoffs also featured considerably higher ODD

shares (> 95%) than the 2022 Senate contests (~ 66%), implying a weaker treatment in Study 2. Finally, the electoral stakes of Study 1—in which Georgia voters knew that they were deciding partisan control of the U.S. Senate—were considerably higher. These differences may limit the comparability of Study 1 and Study 2 results.

Still, while the contexts and designs of Study 1 and Study 2 differ, the results are generally consistent. In both Study 1 and Study 2 the average treatment effect of ODD information in the All Candidates condition is null, but the estimated effect of ODD information conditional on local identity is statistically significant. ODD information triggers a rivalrous view of representation conditional on local identity.

A final limitation of the present work lies in its implicitly bundled treatment. Here the ODD Treatment describes a candidate whose campaign finances are largely sourced from outside the representative's district. Because opinions about the amount of contributions—no matter their source—may impact respondents' views of representational quality, our treatment cannot disentangle the effects of campaign finance sources from those of campaign finance amounts.

Conclusion

This paper tackles out-of-district donations and surrogate representation from a new perspective—that of a legislator's geographic constituents. Study 1 demonstrates that informing respondents about a Georgia Senate candidate's ODD share prompts them to predict that their senator will spend significantly less time and effort working for the interests of Georgians. This trade-off is felt most acutely by those with strong local identity, suggesting that these voters feel representation to be rivalrous, or zero-sum. Study 2 unpacks a key mechanism driving these results: local identity. We show that priming local identity leads respondents to view ODDs as significantly undermining representational expectations.

Our results suggest that Representative Barney Frank may have been wrong when he declared that his constituents back home understood his position as a surrogate representative. While he may not have believed that his stated role as a surrogate took up much of his time and effort, our findings suggest that many of his constituents may have disagreed.¹⁷ We interpret these findings as evidence that out-of-district donations and surrogate representation entail important trade-offs between a representative's geographic constituents and their surrogate constituents.

Geographic constituents confronted with ODDs often view representation as rivalrous, and those firmly rooted to their state feel these trade-offs even more acutely. We find that geographic constituents feel crowded out and neglected when they learn that specific candidates accept ODDs. These feelings of neglect have

¹⁷ There are important differences between the Frank example and our test here. Unlike this analysis, Frank is focusing on descriptive identity-based surrogate representation, while we focus on the material donations of monetary surrogacy. Future work should explore possible differences in geographic constituents' reactions to descriptive identity-based surrogate representation and monetary surrogacy.

implications for how they evaluate their legislators and Congress as a whole. When they learn about ODDs, geographic constituents expect their representatives to spend less time and effort on their local interests. In other words, many geographic constituents see sharing their representatives with outsiders as detrimental to their representatives' ability to work for geographic constituents.

This trade-off is felt most acutely by constituents whose interests are especially attached to their local place. These voters must depend on their elected representative to fight for local issues and interests, which would never be represented by a surrogate from another district. Perhaps most importantly, this is not an irrational feeling on the part of voters. Empirical work finds that constituents are correct that the quality of their representation is diminished by ODDs (Baker, 2016, 2020; Canes-Wrone & Miller, 2022).

These results build on a rich literature investigating how campaign donations can affect citizens' views of their representatives. For example, past work has probed how citizens perceive donations from individuals, corporations, and unions (Bowler & Donovan, 2016).¹⁸ Other scholarship has found that the type of media citizens consume shapes their beliefs about donations (Brewer et al., 2017) and that voters know little about campaign finance (Primo & Milyo, 2020; Shaw et al., 2021). Our research contributes to this literature by highlighting how the geographic source of campaign donations can shape citizens' perceptions. While citizens may know little about campaign finance, our findings suggest that information about it can nonetheless shape citizens' political attitudes.

This study also has implications for normative questions of democratic legitimacy. Surrogate representation may indeed be a crucial element of democratic legitimacy in single-member district systems, as Mansbridge argues (2003, 523; 2011, 627–8). Additionally, the practice of out-of-district donations may be important to freedoms of political participation and speech. But our findings suggest that the pervasive practice of out-of-district donations plays a more complicated role in that story. There are some interests and perspectives—those pertaining to local issues in particular—that simply cannot be reflected in the overall composition of the legislature.¹⁹

We hope that this study prompts more research on geographic constituents and out-of-district donations. Many empirical questions remain unanswered: Do citizens respond more negatively if ODDs come from particular places, such as coastal or urban centers? Which issues do geographic constituents find most salient? If constituents feel that ODDs reduce representatives' time and effort on local issues, what are the downstream consequences? Do geographic constituents in House races view out-of-district donations differently from out-of-state donations? Our research also points the way toward an additional avenue for normative scholarship: How should single-member district systems absorb these negative feelings without sacrificing a

¹⁸ Some find that individual contributions are more likely to be seen as a corrupt (DeBell & Iyengar, 2021).

¹⁹ The tension between democracy and local attachments stretches back to the origins of democratic institutions in ancient Athens, see Nathan (2022).

standard of democratic legitimacy? Given the pervasiveness of ODDs in contemporary American politics, the political consequences of monetary surrogacy remain an important frontier for future work.

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Data Availability All data and R code necessary for replication has been posted to the Political Behavior Dataverse at <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/2BA5OY> (Nathan et al. 2024).

Declarations

Conflict of interest None of the authors declares a conflict of interest related to this work.

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